



Institute of Legal Research

IDEA LEGAL RESEARCH PAPER SERIES

No. 2026-40

ISSN 2943-4068

© Copyright: IDEA
Institute of Legal Research

Suggested citation:

Naik, Yeshwant. "An Anthropological Observation of Hospitality Dynamics in Münster's Restaurant Scene". IDEA Legal Research Paper Series No. 2026-40, pp.2-4.

An Anthropological Observation of Hospitality Dynamics in Münster's Restaurant Scene

On November 22, 2025, between 7 pm and 8 pm, I visited a restaurant located in Stevern Nottuln,¹ Germany. The establishment exuded a cozy, inviting atmosphere with a warm fireplace and a countryside feel, complemented by a spacious, beautifully decorated dining hall suitable for both intimate gatherings and large groups. Its traditional yet elegant aesthetic catered to a diverse, mainly older clientele, reflecting a preference for comfort and quality over novelty. The menu was predominantly non-vegetarian, with fewer than ten vegetarian options, and dishes were priced above €17, with soups around €8

We had reserved our table in advance, and the restaurant's capacity allowed for accommodating large parties. I estimated the staff comprised around fifty or more employees, most of whom were migrants from various countries—African, Egyptian, Turkish, Eastern European—while only one or two appeared to be native Germans or Europeans. This demographic composition mirrors broader trends in the hospitality industry, where migrant workers often fill roles that are difficult to staff with local Europeans.

The physical environment was appealing, with well-maintained decor and a comfortable ambiance. However, the service experience revealed a noticeable decline in work ethic and enthusiasm. The waiters and waitresses, dressed uniformly in white shirts and black trousers or jackets, appeared exhausted, disengaged, and lacking the smiles typical of European hospitality staff. Their demeanour suggested fatigue and possibly pressure from understaffing, as the owner reportedly provides accommodation to workers, indicating limited staffing options. Making eye contact to call them for service was challenging; they often struggled to understand non-German orders and asked for repetitions, though they responded immediately to my German friend's order.

An intriguing aspect was the apparent pattern of bias and differential treatment. Non-European staff tended to greet Europeans or Germans with more warmth—smiling and engaging—whereas migrants or customers with non-European looks often received minimal acknowledgment. When they did smile, it was usually directed toward lighter-skinned Europeans, especially if they appeared older or more affluent. For instance, I observed an African waitress chatting, joking, and smiling predominantly with older

¹ Nottuln is situated approximately 20 kilometers west of Münster and 15 kilometers east of Coesfeld, on the southwestern edge of the Baumberge (highest hills in the natural regions of Münsterland and Kernmünsterland with a maximum height of 187.6 m above sea level). It shares borders with Billerbeck, Havixbeck, Senden, Dülmen, and Coesfeld. A junction bearing the same name is located five kilometers southeast of Nottuln, providing access to Bundesautobahn 43, which links the Ruhr region with Münster.

German customers—perhaps aiming to attract tips or because of their lighter skin—while she did not extend the same friendliness to migrant customers. This subtle discrimination extended to non-verbal cues, with limited eye contact and a lack of genuine hospitality toward darker-skinned or migrant patrons, reflecting underlying social biases.

The staff's behaviour reflected broader issues of racial bias and workplace discrimination, contributing to a stratified service environment. The migrant workers appeared to perform emotional labour selectively, perhaps influenced by social stereotypes or perceived customer expectations. Such differential treatment creates an atmosphere where genuine hospitality is compromised, and the service quality visibly suffers. For example, some staff members greeted or engaged more warmly with European customers, while their interactions with migrants remained superficial or indifferent.

The overall service lacked warmth and enthusiasm, contrasting sharply with typical European standards where staff often smile and show genuine engagement—even if somewhat artificial. The staff seemed lost in their thoughts, inattentive, and not very vigilant, making it difficult to make eye contact or call them for service. This disengagement is reminiscent of trends observed in Münster's supermarkets, where cashier staff often show little enthusiasm or engagement under pressure, although European staff tend to maintain friendliness consistently.

The clientele and pricing further emphasized the establishment's focus on an older demographic, with dishes over €17 and soups around €8. While the food was good, the fish quality was disappointing, and the hospitality had declined—the spirit and enthusiasm that might have previously characterized such a place seemed diminished. An African waitress, for example, interacted with older German customers, chatting and joking more readily, possibly to attract tips or due to their lighter skin. She did not extend the same friendly treatment to migrant or darker-skinned customers, highlighting a pattern of selective friendliness.

This scenario can be analysed through frameworks like Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory,² particularly regarding Power Distance and Uncertainty Avoidance,³ which influence staff perceptions of authority and customer interactions. Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory⁴ may also explain the lack of motivation, as poor working conditions,

² Żemojtel-Piotrowska, Magdalena, and Jarosław Piotrowski. "Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory." *ResearchGate*, 2023, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/371822907_Hofstede%27s_Cultural_Dimensions_Theory. Accessed 26 Nov. 2025.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Abdulkhmidova, Fazilat. "Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory." *ResearchGate*, 2021, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/352465259_Herzberg%27s_Two-Factor_Theory. Accessed 26 Nov. 2025.

perceived unfair treatment, and lack of recognition diminish job satisfaction and enthusiasm.⁵

In conclusion, the restaurant visit in Nottuln revealed more than just culinary preferences; it highlighted the complex interplay of workforce diversity, service quality, and social biases. While the physical ambiance remains inviting, the service experience underscores the need for addressing underlying issues of worker motivation, cultural sensitivity, and equitable treatment. Recognizing and fostering genuine hospitality, irrespective of ethnicity, is essential for elevating the quality of service and promoting a more inclusive hospitality culture.

⁵ Ibid.